Review of key Concepts – Week 1

1. **Define a project. What are five characteristics which help differentiate projects from other functions carried out in the daily operations of the organization?**

   A project is a complex, non-routine, one-time effort limited by time, budget, resource, and specifications. Differentiating characteristics of projects from routine, repetitive daily work are below:

   a. A defined life span
   b. A well-defined objective
   c. Typically involves people from several disciplines
   d. A project life cycle
   e. Specific time, cost, and performance requirements.

2. **What is project management?**

   Project management is the art and science of using knowledge, skills, tools, and techniques efficiently and effectively to meet stakeholder needs and expectations. This includes work processes that initiate, plan, execute, control, and close work.

   Project management includes both administrative tasks for planning, documenting, and controlling work and leadership tasks for visioning, motivating, and promoting work associates.

3. **How are projects different than ongoing operations?**

   Projects are temporary while operations are ongoing.

4. **What are some of the key environmental forces that have changed the way projects are managed? What has been the effect of these forces on the management of projects?**

   Some environmental forces that have changed the way we manage projects are the product life cycle, knowledge growth, global competition, organization downsizing, technology changes, time-to-market. The impact of these forces is more projects per organization, project teams responsible for implementing projects, accountability, changing organization structures, need for rapid completion of projects, linking projects to organization strategy and customers, prioritizing projects to conserve organization resources, alliances with external organizations, and so on.

5. **Why is the implementation of projects important to strategic planning and the project manager?**

   Strategic plans are implemented primarily through projects—e.g., a new product, a new information system, a new plant for a new product. The project manager is the key person responsible for completing the project on time, on budget, and within specifications so the project's customer is satisfied. If the project is not linked to the strategic plan of the organization, resources devoted to the project are wasted and a

customer need is not met. This lack of connectivity occurs more in practice than most would believe.

6. **The technical and sociocultural dimensions of project management are two sides to the same coin. Explain.**

   The system and sociocultural dimensions of project management are two sides of the same coin because successful project managers are skillful in both areas. The point is successful project managers need to be very comfortable and skillful in *both* areas.

7. **What are three common ways of classifying projects? (objective #5, pp. 16-17)**

   Projects can be classified by industry, size, when scope can be determined with confidence, and type such as organizational change, quality and productivity improvement, R&D, information systems (IS), and construction.

8. **What are project executive-level roles?**

   There are four project executive level roles in traditional project management: sponsor, customer, steering team, and project management office. The sponsor has a financial stake in the project, charters the project, reviews project progress, is often part of the steering team, and often mentors the project manager. The customer needs to ensure that a good contractor for external projects or project manager for internal projects is selected, make sure requirements are clear, and maintain communications throughout the project. A steering or leadership team for an organization is often the top leader (CEO or other) and his or her direct reports. The project management office (PMO) is the keeper, facilitator, and improver of the project management system.